EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Is Gehinnom Forever?

Given Monday 3 November 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 9:7-8

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 9 (Olam HaBa, The World to Come), the second half of Chapter 7 and Chapter 8

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 3 November 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: The Questions So Far

The Rabbi opened by saying he was not feeling well, but did not want to cancel, since there would be no other shiurim that week.

In Essay 9 Saadia has brought proofs for Olam HaBa from logic, Torah and tradition, and has begun answering his questions about its nature:

Question	Saadia's answer
1 and 2: reward and punishment	The **light** and the **heat** of a sun
3: place	A **new** place, newly created
4: time	**No time** as we know it; day and night, months and years are only for the needs of this world
5 and 6: eternity	Both reward and punishment are **eternal**

Why eternal? Last week: if the reward were limited, a person could complain, "Had You given me a greater incentive, I would have served You." So Hashem gives the greatest incentive, eternal reward, and no excuse remains. The same with punishment: had it been only a thousand or five thousand years, a person could say a real, eternal threat would have kept him from sin. And if someone suggests the threat is only a threat, Saadia replies that Hashem has said it, and what He says He keeps.

Chapter 7 (continued): Proofs That It Is Forever

Saadia now brings verses showing that Olam HaBa is eternal:

(Daniel 12:2) **אלה לחיי עולם ואלה לחרפות לדראון עולם**

Some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt.

Since for Saadia techiyat hametim leads into Olam HaBa, this shows clearly that both the reward and the punishment are eternal.

נעמות בימינך נצח (Tehillim 16:11): pleasures at Your right hand forever.

עד נצח לא יראו אור (Tehillim 49:20): they will never see light, for eternity.

ושנותיך לא יתמו. בני עבדיך ישכונו וזרעם לפניך יכון (Tehillim 102:28-29): Your years will not end; the children of Your servants will dwell, and their descendants will be established before You. As Hashem endures forever, so will they before Him.

If the future is endless, why not the past?

Someone might argue: if created beings can exist with Hashem **without end** at the end of time, why could they not have existed **without beginning** at the start of time?

There is a big difference, says Saadia. It is impossible for a created thing to have always existed alongside its Creator, because **every maker must precede what he makes**. Since Hashem made us, He was before us, so we cannot be eternal in the past. But once He has made us, just as we see that He sustains us every day, He can sustain us tomorrow, and having promised to do so, He can sustain us day after day forever. Reason has no difficulty with that. So: **a beginning there must be, but an end there need not be.**

Then are we equal to God?

A last point: if we exist forever, are we not equal to the Creator? That is plainly false, says Saadia. How can a being of body and spirit, which needs time and place, which receives pleasure, which is commanded and warned, and which depends on being kept in existence, be compared to the One who is exalted above all these? Even in eternity we remain His creations, with limits, while He has none.

Is Eternal Punishment the Accepted View?

"You'll say that's probably the correct approach, the view of the Chachamim. And that's generally what we're brought up with, that Olam HaBa is eternal. The thing is, it's not entirely clear in the Gemara that that's the case."

The Gemara in Rosh Hashanah

פושעי ישראל בגופן ופושעי אומות העולם בגופן יורדין לגיהנם ונידונין בה שנים עשר חדש. לאחר שנים עשר חדש גופן כלה ונשמתן נשרפת ורוח מפזרתן תחת כפות רגלי הצדיקים... אבל המינין והמסורות והאפיקורסין... יורדין לגיהנם ונידונין בה לדורי דורות (Rosh Hashanah 17a)

Sinners of Israel and of the nations with their bodies go down to Gehinnom and are judged there for twelve months. After twelve months their body is consumed, their soul is burnt, and the wind scatters them under the soles of the feet of the righteous... But the heretics, the informers and the apikorsim... go down to Gehinnom and are judged there for all generations.

So most sinners, "probably lots of us," go to Gehinnom for **at most twelve months**. Only those with the gravest sins, the deniers of the Torah, are judged for generations.

How does Saadia square this? For him there is either eternal Gan Eden or eternal Gehinnom. Into which category fall those punished for twelve months who then receive eternal bliss? Perhaps

one would have to say that for Saadia most people never go to Gehinnom at all, and only the real heretics receive eternal Gehinnom. But Saadia never mentions the twelve months anywhere in his writings.

Tosafot: even the worst are not forever

Another Gemara says:

כל היורדין לגיהנם עולין, חוץ משלשה שיורדין ואין עולין

All who go down to Gehinnom come up, except for three who go down and do not come up.

That seems to say at least three categories receive eternal punishment. But **Tosafot** says: **אין לפרש דאין עולים לעולם**, it cannot mean they never come up. Rather, everyone else comes up **immediately**, and the fire of Gehinnom barely touches them; the three do not come up immediately, but they do come up. Even those who have no share in Olam HaBa are not judged for more than twelve months:

אלא לאחר י"ב חודש לא חיין ולא נידונין, ושרויין בלא טובה ובלא רעה

After twelve months they neither live nor are judged, and remain without good and without bad.

"You could say it's similar to the Rambam in this, but let's not go there now." The point is that Tosafot reads "they do not come up" as **לאו דווקא**, not literally. In Tosafot's mind, at least as one approach, it was not settled that Gehinnom is eternal. And Tosafot obviously does not accept Saadia's reasoning that a limited threat would leave people an excuse.

The **Mishnah in Eduyot** says plainly:

משפט רשעים בגיהנם שנים עשר חדש

The judgment of the wicked in Gehinnom is twelve months.

You could say this means ordinary sinners, and the great heretics last longer. "What bothers me though, is Saadia makes no reference to these mentions at all in the Gemara of twelve months."

Why this is only a problem for Saadia

The difficulty arises only because Saadia **equates Gan Eden and Gehinnom with Olam HaBa**. The Rambam, the Ramban and "the vast majority of Rishonim" do not. For them, all these Gemarot describe a kind of **purging**, limited to twelve months, after which one goes on to Olam HaBa, which is something new. But for Saadia, whenever the Mishnah and Talmud speak of Gehinnom they are speaking of Olam HaBa, and they say the wicked receive twelve months. "There is an end, it is finite, it's not eternal. So, I think it's open for interpretation."

Other dissenting voices

- **Rabbi Yitzchak Aboab da Fonseca**, about 400 years ago. The Rabbi could not find his book either in print or online, but saw it quoted: he argued, against a lot of opposition, that **there is no eternal damnation in Judaism**. The Rabbi shared an article about him in the chat. "He's not so well known, but there was such an opinion."
- **Rabbi Chasdai Crescas**, in the **Or HaShem**. Crescas was the teacher of Rabbi Yosef Albo of the Ikarim, both in Spain. The Rabbi read a passage in which Crescas speaks of the final loss of the soul after the suffering of Gehinnom as the loss of its preparedness, "as if it remains naked, without preparation," which Chazal called "ashes," the remains of what is burnt. And when the loss is not of the final degree, "it is not far-fetched that there should be a **temporary purging**,

as His wisdom decrees." (The Rabbi mentioned that the class might study the Or HaShem after finishing Emunot VeDeot.)

The Rambam

"Just to repeat what we've learned in the past about the Rambam, my understanding of the Rambam, and it's pretty clear this is his approach": the greatest punishment is **karet**. There is no hellfire. All the references in Shas to the soul being burnt are metaphors for being cut off and having no portion in Olam HaBa. The Rambam does have a **temporary Gehinnom** for purging. But there is no eternal damnation, unless one reads the Rambam (which is possible) as saying that the person who is cut off remains aware of it and suffers eternal shame at what he lost. "It's not certain either way. But there isn't a vengeful constant punishing. That's not in the Rambam's books."

Summary on eternity

View	Reward	Punishment
Saadia	Eternal	Eternal, for every rasha
The Gemara (simple reading)	Eternal	Twelve months of purging for most; perhaps eternal for a few
Tosafot (one suggestion)	Eternal	At most twelve months, then neither good nor bad
Aboab, Crescas		Not eternal / possibly temporary
Rambam	Eternal	Eternal **loss**, being cut off: "an eternal missed opportunity," not torment

"All of these things are very open, with different views. Saadia is not on the fence here."

Chapter 8, Question 7: Is Everyone's Reward the Same?

One mitzvah, one sin

Saadia says something very interesting:

כמו שלא יכלה גמול אלף זכיות, כן לא יכלה גמול זכות אחת. וכמו שאלף חובה לא יכלה עונשה, כן חובה אחת לא יכלה עונשה

Just as the reward of a thousand merits never ends, so the reward of one merit never ends. And just as the punishment of a thousand sins never ends, so the punishment of one sin never ends.

So what is the difference between one and a thousand? Both are eternal, but each person's lot is **commensurate with his deeds**. Whoever does one merit, or ten, or a hundred, or a thousand, will be rewarded according to what he did, only it is eternal.

Levels of a good life

Saadia's analogy is life in this world:

- Some people's good fortune is simply **tranquillity**.

- Others have tranquillity and also **eat and drink** the best.
- Others have all that and **fine clothes**.
- Others have all that and **high rank and position**.

So too in Olam HaBa, each with a verse:

ישכן לבטח: some will simply dwell in safety, relaxed.

בצל כנפיך יחסיון (Tehillim 36:8): others shelter in the shadow of Hashem's wings, "a bit more".

ירוין מדשן ביתך (Tehillim 36:9): others are sated from the abundance of His house.

והלבש אתך מחלצות (Zecharyah 3:4): others are clothed in fine garments. "He's taking this so literally".

ונתתי לך מהלכים בין העמדים האלה (Zecharyah 3:7): the highest walk among the angels who stand, **שרפים עמדים ממעל לו** (Yeshayahu 6:2).

The person of a thousand mitzvot is with the angels. The person of one mitzvah has eternity too, "but it's eternal tranquillity. That's it."

Levels of punishment

And the reverse. In this world, some are punished by being **held in custody**; others are also **dragged with ropes**; others are **bound**; others are bound in **chains and fetters**; and others, besides all that, are **beaten** with painful blows. So too in Olam HaBa:

ואספו אספה אסיר על בור וסגרו על מסגר (Yeshayahu 24:22): gathered as prisoners in a pit and locked up.

עוונותיו ילכדנו את הרשע ובחבלי חטאתו יתמך (Mishlei 5:22): his iniquities will trap the wicked, and he will be held by the cords of his sin.

- Others in **shackles**.

וסער מתגורר על ראש רשעים יחול (Yirmiyahu 23:19): a raging storm will burst on the head of the wicked.

"This does seem very reductive, I have to say."

What everyone agrees on

The concept of **levels** in Olam HaBa is agreed by all: the Rambam says it clearly, the Ramban says it clearly. The Rabbi recalled his analogy of seats in a stadium. "He puts it in very material terms, which is what I find difficult. But the concept is agreed upon by all": the level you reach corresponds to the mitzvot you have done. Saadia extends this to levels of punishment too.

The Rabbi added that the **Rambam**, in his commentary to the end of Makkot, says something similar about a single mitzvah: if you do one mitzvah **properly**, with no self-interest at all, "which is very difficult," you are guaranteed a place in Olam HaBa, because that act has made an impact on your character.

The Problem: What If I Have Both?

"Who can tell me the obvious question on this?" If one mitzvah earns eternal bliss and one sin earns eternal Gehinnom, what about someone with a thousand mitzvot and one sin? Most of us have great middot and also flaws; we do many good things and some bad, and most of us will

end with some sin for which we have not done teshuvah. How can I have both eternal Gan Eden and eternal Gehinnom?

The Rambam would answer simply. Every sin has an impact on you, but at the end of your life we look at **all your actions together**: your good deeds, your moral and intellectual perfection, your negative traits. We assess who you are as an entire person, and that determines your level for eternity.

The Ramban would not have the problem either, because for him there is a waiting room: twelve months of Gehinnom for purging. Saadia has no waiting room. Olam HaBa is Gan Eden and Gehinnom for eternity, and each mitzvah and each aveirah is eternal.

"Can't you subtract the sins from the mitzvot?"

A participant suggested deducting one from the other. "That's a nice attempt, but it doesn't work like that." The pasuk in Ekev says Hashem **אשר לא ישא פנים ולא יקח שחד** (Devarim 10:17), does not show favour and takes no bribe. How can one bribe God? The Midrash says: **the bribe of mitzvot**. As the Ramban explains on this pasuk, you cannot weigh a mitzvah against an aveirah. Even after a whole life of mitzvot, one sin without teshuvah must face its consequence, whether in this world, in Gehinnom or elsewhere. Everyone agrees there is no cancelling-out game. That is why, when children come home before Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur with pictures of scales, the Rabbi always takes time to explain: "For little kids, fine, it's a weighing up, but there's no concept of weighing up." A participant offered the image of **two different bank accounts**. "Exactly."

Saadia's answer: two boxes

Saadia already answered this in the essay on merits and demerits (Essay 5). He takes a very simple view: **everyone is either a tzaddik or a rasha**, judged by the majority of their deeds.

- **51% good, 49% bad:** you are a tzaddik, a ben Olam HaBa, at a low level (tranquillity, no "metaphorical beautiful clothes"). Your 49% of sins are **punished in this world**, through its sufferings.
- **51% bad, 49% good:** you are a rasha with eternal damnation, though not as severe as someone at 99%. Your 49% of mitzvot are **rewarded in this world**.
- **Exactly 50-50:** the beinoni. Hashem is **מטה כלפי חסד**, inclines toward kindness, and gives Olam HaBa.

"Already at that time, I found that concept very difficult, and I still do." It is "just two boxes. It's very extreme, it's very simplistic." Within each box there are levels, and there is no mixture. For the Rambam, by contrast, we look at your whole identity, and only HaKadosh Baruch Hu can make that calculation: **כי לא מחשבותי מחשבותיכם**.

If a mitzvah's reward is eternal, how can a rasha be paid for it in this world, and how can a tzaddik's sin be punished here? "It's a famous question, there are answers to it." The class had discussed it in the past.

A question about gilgul

A participant suggested that perhaps someone is punished by coming back to earth for a hard life. The Rabbi answered that reincarnation is not the traditional view. Saadia did not believe in it, nor did the Rambam, and there is no mention of it anywhere in Shas or Midrash. "But having said that, there are opinions which do believe in it." It appears in the **Zohar**, and is held from the

Ramban onwards; the Ramban explains the whole of Iyov through gilgulim. But even after the Ramban many disagreed: **Rabbi Yosef Albo** threw it out, as did **Menasheh ben Israel**. Only from the time of the **Arizal**, about 500 years ago, did it become doctrine. "Until then it was still a debate."

Seven Levels of Light, Seven Levels of Fire

Saadia now elaborates on the levels. Reason requires that the righteous have degrees, each above the other, and Scripture shows **seven** of them, each described with a different verse about light. "Remember, this is all based on Saadia's view of Olam HaBa, the reward being light."

Level	The righteous receive	Verse
1	Light like the rays of the sun	**וזרחה לכם יראי שמי שמש צדקה** (Malachi 3:20)
2	Delight in its rays	**ומרפא בכנפיה** (Malachi 3:20)
3	Light that stays, as if planted	**אור זרע לצדיק** (Tehillim 97:11)
4	Ever-increasing light	**אור צדיקים ישמח** (Mishlei 13:9)
5	Light like the firmament	**והמשכלים יזהרו כזהר הרקיע** (Daniel 12:3)
6	Light like the stars	**ומצדיקי הרבים ככוכבים לעולם ועד** (Daniel 12:3)
7	Light like the sun itself	**ואהביו כצאת השמש בגבורתו** (Shoftim 5:31)

He supports the idea of degrees from Moshe and those below him. **Moshe's** face shone; **Yehoshua's** less, as Hashem told Moshe **ונתתה מהודך עליו** (Bamidbar 27:20), "some of your majesty," not all of it; and the **seventy elders** less still: **ויאצל מן הרוח אשר עליו ויתן על שבעים איש הזקנים** (Bamidbar 11:25). The purpose of giving Yehoshua some of Moshe's majesty was **למען ישמעו כל עדת בני ישראל**, so that the whole community, including the elders, would listen to him. So there were levels: Moshe, Yehoshua, the elders. As in this world, so in the next.

And the wicked likewise have **seven levels of fire**:

Level	The wicked receive	Verse
1	Fire that reddens the face	**פני להבים פניהם** (Yeshayahu 13:8)
2	Faces blackened like a burnt pot	**כל פנים קבצו פארור** (Yoel 2:6)
3	Roasting and cooking	**הנה היום בא בער כתנור** (Malachi 3:19)
4	Fire that consumes	**תאכלהו אש לא נפח** (Iyov 20:26)
5	Fire consuming wood	**מדרתה אש ועצים** (Yeshayahu 30:33)
6	Fire consuming earth and stones	**ותאכל ארץ ויבלה** (Devarim 32:22)
7	Fire in the depths of the earth	**כי אש היא עד אבדון תאכל** (Iyov 31:12)

Just as the plagues of Egypt struck everyone, but each according to his measure, as it says **יפלס נתיב לאפו** (Tehillim 78:50), He weighs out a path for His anger. And **יפלס ומאזני משפט לה'** (Mishlei 16:11): the balance and scales of justice are Hashem's.

The number seven

The Rabbi noted a Midrash in the name of **Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai** about **seven kinds of faces** of the righteous: like the sun, the moon, the firmament, the stars, lightning, roses and the Menorah. "The concept of seven levels is a very old concept." That is also why at the end of Ne'ilah we say **ה' הוא האלהים** seven times, as if the Shechinah is ascending back through the seven levels.

"But you see how literally Saadia is taking all of this." For the Rambam there are certainly levels, though not specifically seven. "Every human being is going to be in a different level. Maybe there are seven categories, but certainly each person will be taken into account in his entire framework, who he is."

Summary and Looking Ahead

- **Eternity:** Saadia holds reward and punishment are both eternal. Many Rishonim agree, but there are dissenting views: the Gemara's twelve months, Tosafot, Aboab, Crescas. The Rambam's eternal punishment is eternal loss, not torment.
- **Levels:** for Saadia there are really only **two categories**, tzaddik or rasha, but within each there are **seven sub-levels**, of light or of fire.

Next week: Do we see each other in Olam HaBa? Do the righteous see the wicked and the wicked the righteous, and does each group see its own? Is there service of Hashem in Olam HaBa? Is there free will? "Shocking things we're going to learn." There would be no shiur that Tuesday or Thursday; the full schedule would resume the following week.

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